Week 26

JOURNEY

JOURNEY: ADVOCATES® · LEADER HANDOUT · UNIT 7 · LESSON 2

Falsehood

BIG IDEA

Some say an all-powerful, all-good God would simply have prevented evil, but being all-powerful doesn't mean God can do anything: he cannot lie or contradict himself. God didn't create evil, he allows it only for a time for reasons we see in part, and he gives us real hope.

Key points from the Leader Video

1. This lesson answers a common atheist objection: if God is all-powerful and all-good, he would have prevented evil in the first place.
2. In a debate, an atheist argued God would have made a perfect "God-world" of only God-like things. But then God would no longer be God; that leads to pantheism.
3. There are some things God cannot do, such as lie or contradict himself. Help students think about what makes God God, not trick questions like the heavy rock.
4. God did not create evil and is not responsible for it. He is working to remedy it, yet he still lets us have free will to make our own choices.
5. God has morally justified reasons to allow evil for a time. As Paul says in 1 Corinthians, we only see in part; like a parent, God may know what we can't.
6. Know what your students are going through, both to pray and walk with them and to avoid touching a raw nerve. Point them to God for hope, not doubt.

FOR YOU

Before club: think it through yourself.

1. What do I actually believe about why God allows evil, and where do I still only see in part?
2. What is each of my students going through right now that I should keep in mind this week?
3. When has something painful in my life later been used for good?

ASK YOUR GROUP

In small group: questions to ask your students.

1. What are some things God cannot do, and what do they tell us about who he is?
2. Why would a world where everything is equal to God mean God isn't God anymore?
3. What good have you seen come out of something bad, in your life or someone else's?
4. How is God allowing evil for a time different from God causing evil?
5. When evil seems to win, what would help you look to God for hope rather than doubt him?

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WEEK 26 · LEADER VIDEO

The full transcript

The talk from this week's Leader Video, lightly edited for reading. Times point back to that moment in the video.

A common atheist objection

0:05 So, 7.2 — we call it falsehood. This lesson really is a response to a common atheist objection: that if God were so big and mighty and powerful and sovereign and all good, then he would have prevented evil. He wouldn't have allowed it in the first place. I mean, think about it: if God can do these things, if God can just speak and suddenly we have a universe, then why can't he prevent evil?

0:36 Years ago I did a debate with an atheist, and this was essentially his argument. His argument was pretty complex, but let me summarize it as quickly as I can. He basically said that if God existed, God would have created a world in which only God-like objects existed, and he called that God-world. And if this God-world were an actual world, then all the pieces of God-world would be just like God. There would be no suffering, there would be no evil, there would be nothing at all. Everything would be absolutely perfect, on an equal playing field with God.

1:17 My response was pretty simple. It took me some time to figure out exactly what he was saying, and then it hit me. I said, "First, why do you think this is the case?" And he said, "Well, because there's evil and suffering in the world." I said, "Let's put that aside for a second. Is there anything that God cannot do?" And he said, "Well, if God is all-powerful, then there's nothing that God cannot do. That's why, if he can't prevent evil, then God must not exist." I said, "That's not the case. Just because God is all-powerful and sovereign and omniscient and all-awesome, does that mean there's nothing that God cannot do?"

2:02 So, unfortunately, the old song — "my God is so great, my God is so big, there's nothing…" — is actually not necessarily true. Because God could not create a world in which only God-like objects, or God-like things that are equivalent to him, existed. Because if that were the case, then God would not exist, because he wouldn't be God anymore. He would just be equal to everything else; everything would be the same as God, and all things would be God, and that would take us into a form of pantheism. So his argument didn't work.

God is not responsible for evil

2:45 But there's this understanding of, well, why wouldn't God do that? Simply put, there are some things that God actually cannot do. And what's important about this lesson is to help students understand that God is not the one who is responsible for evil. God did not create it. As I said last week, it's not a thing to be created, because evil is not a thing. God did not create it; God is not responsible. And although God is doing something to remedy the situation, he still has to allow us to have free will to make our own choices.

What God cannot do

3:14 So this week, I would get your students thinking about the character and nature of who God is. Have them think about it, just like in the intro activity, where we ask them about things that are impossible for humanity to do — but what about things that are impossible for God to do? What are some other things that maybe God cannot do? Have your students think that through: what makes God God, and what limits does God actually have?

3:41 Now, I don't mean fun things like "Can God create a rock so big he can't lift it?" and strange questions like that. That's not what I'm talking about. I mean things like this: God cannot contradict himself. God cannot lie. So have your students think that through, to help paint a better picture of the nature of God and of exactly what he's doing in this world to remedy the evil and the suffering that is so prevalent.

Morally justified reasons

4:08 So God has morally justified reasons for allowing the temporary existence of evil and suffering in our world. That may seem like a cop-out — like, what, that's the best you've got? But remember what Scripture says, what Paul says in 1 Corinthians: we only see things in part right now. We don't have the full picture. There's still quite a bit of mystery going on.

4:34 The example I always used to give my students was the example of being a kid, or of parenting my own kids. I may know what's best for my kids. They may not realize that I know what's best, and what I'm telling them they have to do, or what I'm putting them through, may seem like a terrible, terrible thing for them in that moment. The whole world is coming crashing down on them, and yet I know exactly what I'm doing, and it's for their good. That may be the case sometimes. And sometimes it's just the case that evil is evil, and evil just happens. God doesn't like it any more than we do, but he has to allow it, even if only for a time.

5:13 And as we'll see later on, when we get to more of the pastoral approach to this question of evil, it can be used for something exceptionally good. So in your small groups, I want you to start to brainstorm a little bit about what good can come from evil. But I also want you to be very aware — I keep beating this drum — very aware of the questions that are coming. If the questions didn't come last week, they may be coming this week, and they may be coming next week. They may be coming all of the weeks.

Know your students

5:46 And be aware of some of the things that your students are going through. By now you probably know your students really well. You probably know their families, you've probably talked with their parents, and you've connected with their families on some level. Do your best to be aware of some of the things that your students are going through, for two reasons. One, so that you can pray with them, and pastor them along, and walk with them, and be there for them in the way that you need to be. That goes without saying.

6:15 But the other is that when we're dealing with these kinds of issues, you want to have an awareness and a sensitivity so that you don't say anything that would touch the wrong nerve with your students. Sometimes you may want to a little bit, to get a response out of students and to move them along, but you also want to be very, very aware of where they are, so that you can minister to them in the best possible way without setting them back at all.

Look to him for hope

6:43 So rather than going down the easy road and simply doubting God because of the evil that we see around us, we can actually look to him for hope. We can know that he has a plan, know that he has a purpose, and know that of all the things we're going through, it's not for nothing. We can look to him for significant hope.